car, as seen in this footage, would be able to tell us something about how the car approached, which barriers it crossed and how.

In the end, more questions than ever remain unanswered, about the conduct of the intelligence and security agencies, about the conduct of the media and about our gullibility as citizens to be quick to condemn, first S.A.R. Geelani, and now Mohammad Afzal. Questions remain about the fact that news channels and papers can see it fit never to apologize either to S.A.R. Geelani or Afsan Guru for the deliberate distortions of the truth that these organs of the media were party to, throughout the course of the trials. Not once did Zee News or any other news channel offer an apology to any of the accused, or to the public, for the emotional stress that their broadcasts may have caused, even as they continued to highlight the 'plight' of the families of the 'martyred' security and other personnel who fell in the line of duty on 13 December 2001. Even in the telecast of 4 August 2005, Zee News considered it necessary to provoke the family members of one of the 'martyred' security personnel into an outburst demanding death for all the accused. It did not however deem it necessary to reflect on the fact that the families of S.A.R. Geelani, Afsan Guru, Shaukat Husain or Mohammad Afzal too had had to suffer, knowing that their loved ones were in prison, that they were brutally tortured, and had to go through the trauma of hearing that they had been awarded death sentences. Not once did any news channel ever apologize for creating and sustaining the climate of suspicion against people who were ultimately acquitted; they did not see it necessary to issue a single note of regret to their viewers for having failed to live up to their stated claims of providing free, fair, fearless and objective reportage. The events of 13 December and their aftermath, along with the sad episode of the Kargil War, are probably the nadir as far as a deviation from media ethics and professional standards are concerned for a vast swathe of the 'free and independent media' in India.

In the end, the truth, or the truths (there may be many and conflicting truths) may yet turn out to be more complex and disturbing than either Zee News or the Supreme Court of India can permit themselves to imagine or ask. Zee News, or 'any other alphabet News' is not asking, at least not yet, any of those slightly difficult questions. And if the Supreme Court of India is to have its way, Afzal is going to hang some day. Some of the answers will die with him. S.A.R. Geelani remains alive, and we hope he lives long, but as he has himself said—let us not celebrate the acquittal of the innocent, let us instead